



Dr. Rick Beldegreen releases an American bald eagle into Uwharrie National Forest at High Rock Lake near Denton on Sunday. The eagle suffered a gunshot wound in January and spent nearly three months recovering at the Carolina Raptor Center near Charlotte.

Photos by TED RICHARDSON/Associated Press

Eagle's hard-fought flight

With rehabilitators' help, injured bird back in wild

By KATHLEEN CURRY

Staff Writer

The eagle has flown.

An American bald eagle found shot in January at High Rock Lake went home Sunday.

Staff from the Carolina Raptor Center near Huntersville released the bird, which then soared easily across High Rock Lake before settling into the forest beyond.

As the graceful bird took off, a crowd of onlookers from Charlotte, Greensboro and Winston-Salem cheered. The Carolina Raptor Center directed the launch at High Rock, about 60 miles northeast of Charlotte, after nearly three months of working to save the endangered bird's life.

"It was beautiful," said Alan Barnhardt, director of the CRC. "This was the first eagle in a long, long while we've been able to (heal) and release."

Bald eagles, America's national bird, are endangered and federally protected from harm. This eagle arrived at the CRC after High Rock Lake resident Marvin Tripp called and said a huge bird was tottering about on his property, looking injured.

Assuming it was one of the hundreds of falcons that CRC specialists rescue yearly, volunteer transporter and falconer Bob Pendergrass went out to Tripp's land to pick up the bird.

"He'd told Marvin to put a box over the bird to keep him still.

WANT TO HELP?

Anyone with information on the eagle's shooting should contact Special Agent Sandra Allred of the U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service at (919) 856-4786, Ext. 34. For more information on the Carolina Raptor Center, visit www.BirdsOfPrey.org.

Bob got there and found a huge grill box on the lawn. When he lifted the box, he started going 'Oh my God, oh my God,' Barnhardt said. "Eagles are that rare."

The eagle released Sunday had been shot in the right wing, shattering two of its major bones. It beat the odds by living and thriving again, Barnhardt said.

Three other bald eagles have made it in recent years to the CRC, one of the top such rehab centers in the country. Only one still lives, and its condition is marginal.

"We rehab a lot of birds - 676 came in last year - but eagles are very, very unusual," Barnhardt said.

The mystery of the bird's injury is being investigated. The eagle was still very young - about 3 years old, in a life expectancy of up to 40 years - and didn't have the telltale white head and tail. But there is no



Mathias Engelmann (left), director of rehabilitation at the Carolina Raptor Center, and Dr. Rick Beldegreen, prepare to release an American bald eagle that had been shot. Beldegreen's successful operation on the bird allowed for its full recovery. Bald eagles are a rarity in North Carolina - there are only 23 known pairs.

sporting bird that approaches the 6-foot-wingspan of a bald eagle, Barnhardt said. And there is a black market in eagle feathers, he said.

"It's doubtful this (shooting) was an accident," he said.

The U.S. Fish and Wildlife Commission is continuing to investigate. A person convicted of harming a bald eagle faces a \$50,000 fine and a year in prison.

The birds have been protected since the 1970s by the Endangered Species Act and the Eagle Protection Act.

Almost extinct after years of hunting and DDT poisoning (in the fish that comprise the bulk of a bald eagle's diet), by the 1970s there were no bald eagles left in North Carolina.

Today, the state is home to 23 pair of bald eagles, Barnhardt said. "You'll see them mainly around the coast, because they are fish eaters, or along the wide major rivers and reservoirs," he said.

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